

El Hajj Chehade, Saiid

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Education

Ecole Polytechnique Fédérale de Lausanne (EPFL)

Lausanne, Switzerland

PhD in Computer Science

Sep 2023 – 2026 (expected)

- Security and Privacy Field. Specializing in Web and Browser Privacy and Security.
- **Expected graduation:** 2026.
- EDIC Fellowship Recipient.
- **Advisor:** Prof. Carmela Troncoso.

American University of Beirut

Beirut, Lebanon

B.E. in Computer and Communication Engineering

Aug 2019 – Jun 2023

- Minor in Applied Mathematics. Graduated with High Distinction (GPA: 4.23/4.0).
- Dean's Honor List (all semesters), Merit Scholarship (3rd in Lebanese national secondary exams).
- **Final Year Project:** Decentralized private polling system using threshold homomorphic encryption and touch-biometric authentication.

Publications

Saiid El Hajj Chehade, Florian Hantke, and Ben Stock. 403 Forbidden? Ethically Evaluating Broken Access Control in the Wild. In: *IEEE Symposium on Security and Privacy (S&P)*. github.com/Saiid2001/vsf. 2025.

Saiid El Hajj Chehade, Ben Stock, and Carmela Troncoso. Double-Edged Shield: On the Fingerprintability of Customized Ad Blockers. In: *USENIX Security Symposium*. github.com/spring-epfl/flfp. 2025.

Saiid El Hajj Chehade, Sandra Siby, and Carmela Troncoso. SINBAD: Saliency-informed detection of breakage caused by ad blocking. In: *IEEE Symposium on Security and Privacy (S&P)*. github.com/spring-epfl/sinbad. 2024.

Work in Progress / Under Submission

Saiid El Hajj Chehade et al. Semantic Page Representations for Large-Scale Web Measurements. Under submission. 2026.

Saiid El Hajj Chehade, Eric Jollès, and Carmela Troncoso. Purpose-Limited Minimal Web Page Loading. Under submission. 2026.

Talks & Presentations

Calgary, Canada	Workshop Talk , (Planned) Breaking the web is good for privacy, HotPET	2026
Dagstuhl, Germany	Workshop Talk , (Planned) Semantic Web Page Representations for Large-Scale LLM-Powered Web Measurement, Dagstuhl Seminar On Web Application Security	2026
Limassol, Cyprus	Workshop Talk , Stealthy Fingerprinting Users with personalized blocking rules, Ad-Filtering Dev Summit	2025
Brooklyn, NY, USA	Invited Talk , Customized Ad-blocker fingerprinting, New York University (NYU)	2025
Bochum, Germany	Invited Talk , Browser Vendor Fingerprinting, Max-Planck Institute for Security and Privacy (MPI-SP)	2025
Remote	Invited Talk , Web Breakage Detection, DuckDuckGo Research Team	2024
Remote	Invited Talk , Web Breakage Detection, Brave Browser Research Team	2024

Research Experience

Research Assistant

Lausanne, Switzerland

SPRING Lab – EPFL

Sep 2023 – Present

- Conducting research at the intersection of web measurement, web privacy, and browser security under Prof. Carmela Troncoso.

Research Consultant
Terre Des Hommes (NGO)

Lausanne, Switzerland
Mar 2025 – Mar 2026

- Analyzed a new online system deployment for security and privacy gaps through systems analysis and stakeholder interviews.
- Produced a report outlining vulnerabilities and actionable recommendations for the organization.

Research Intern
Brave Browser and Imperial College London

London, United Kingdom
Jun 2025 – Aug 2025

- Collaborated with Prof. Hamed Haddadi and the Brave research team on optimized page representations for text-based web agents used in large-scale security and privacy web measurements.
- Produced a middle layer between DOM and Accessibility tree that preserves semantic meaning in the page.
- Validated findings during internship; continuing with an upcoming academic submission.

Visiting Researcher
Secure Web Application Group – CISPA

St. Ingbert, Germany
Jul 2024 – Sep 2024

- Collaborated with Prof. Ben Stock on unsafe parameters and authorization issues in HTTP requests for authenticated sessions.
- Developed a mirrored browser setup for synchronized requests from two controlled user accounts.
- Managed a group of 5 volunteers for large-scale semi-manual experiments.

Undergraduate Research Assistant
American University of Beirut

Beirut, Lebanon
Sep 2022 – Jan 2023

- Worked with Prof. Ibrahim Issa on fairness in machine learning; formulated problem statement and research direction.
- Compiled literature review and prepared a report detailing a taxonomy, directions, and a new definition for fairness.

Research Intern
SPRING Lab – EPFL

Lausanne, Switzerland
Jun 2022 – Aug 2022

- Proposed a differential DOM tree comparison algorithm and redefined the web-breakage problem definition, leading to a published paper (SINBAD, IEEE S&P 2024).
- Built a classification pipeline for web-page breakages to improve ad-blocker usability, achieving accuracy comparable to state-of-the-art.
- Published a USENIX Artifact for WebGraph (smart ad classifier) under supervision of Dr. Sandra Siby.
- Released the first open-source ad-block-enabled web crawling tool (Saaid2001/OpenWPM).

Research Assistant
American University of Beirut

Beirut, Lebanon
Sep 2020 – Dec 2021

- Led an HCD research project with Prof. Hazem Hajj on solving students’ social needs in online education.
- Developed a full virtual campus platform (ElectronJS/Flask) with a mesh-topology conference interface using WebRTC.

Industry Experience

Lead Full Stack Engineer
Test Prep Institute

Beirut, Lebanon
May 2022 – Sep 2023

- Led a team of three to build an online educational platform which reduced student processing time by 70%.
- Architected a secure assessment environment with adaptive questions, access control, and live exam statistics.
- Collaborated with UN agencies to administer online entrance exams for 1000+ prospective instructors.

Blockchain Security Consultant
NiftyCraft

Remote, UAE
Jan 2022 – Aug 2022

- Designed and audited smart contracts for NFT-based authentication and access control mechanisms.
- Implemented token-gated content serving with on-chain verification, deployed to production.

Teaching

EPFL, Switzerland	Fall '23, '24, '25, Teaching Assistant for Introduction to Computer Security	COM-301
EPFL, Switzerland	Spring '25, Teaching Assistant for Advanced Topics in Privacy Enhancing Technologies	CS-523

Supervised Students

EPFL, Switzerland	Master Semester Project , Cristiano Sartori, Synthetic Browser Personas and PET Effects on Ad Distributions	Spring '26
EPFL, Switzerland	Master Semester Project , Alexandre Dunoyer de Segonzac, Deep Advertisement Scanning and Clustering	Fall '25
EPFL, Switzerland	Master Semester Project , Julien Mettler, Systematic evaluation of logged-in cookie sensitivity	Spring '24
EPFL, Switzerland	Master Semester Project , Jonas Gloning, Evaluating the privacy impact of Chrome V3 on web extensions	Spring '24
EPFL, Switzerland	Master Semester Project , Pierre-Louis Bravais, Automated agents for web measurements	Fall '24
EPFL, Switzerland	Master Semester Project , Siim Markus Marvet, Investigating Server-side Google Tag Manager	Fall '24

Awards & Honors

Canada	Best Poster Award , “Purpose-Limited Browsing”, Privacy Enhancing Technologies Symposium (PETS)	2026
Switzerland	EDIC Fellowship , School of Computer Science, EPFL	2023
Switzerland	Fellowship , Summer Research Institute	2023
Lebanon	7x Dean’s Honor List , American University of Beirut	2019–2023
Lebanon	AUB / CNRS Merit Scholarship , 3rd rank in Lebanese national secondary education exams	2019
Lebanon	Prime Minister Honor Award , Awarded for academic excellence in secondary education	2019

Service & Outreach

	PC Member , MADWeb 2026 (co-located with NDSS)	2026
Lausanne, Switzerland	PhD Application Mentor , RAMP Program, EPFL	2024–Present
Beirut, Lebanon	Linux Workshop Instructor , Robotics Club, American University of Beirut (50 students)	Nov 2022
Chehim, Lebanon	Kids Robotics Workshop , Organized robotics course for 20 children; prepared curriculum	

Skills & Languages

Programming	Python (Pandas, TensorFlow, NumPy, Scikit-learn, Spacy), C/C++, JavaScript, SQL, Java, CUDA, Django
Tools	Linux, Bash, $\LaTeX$, React, Docker, Git, Figma, LXD, LLM APIs, Playwright
Languages	English (Professional, IELTS 8.5), French (Bilingual, DELF B2), Arabic (Native)